Sprint 1

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WhosDown: Mobile app that makes pickup sports easier

10 Questions

1. How well does the app fit in with the mobile mindset?

This app fits the mobile mindset well because it supports quick, location- and time-based decisions. A user can decide to play a sport later that day, open the app, see nearby games on the map, and join one in just a few taps. The app requires little setup, supports short and interruptible interactions, and can use location and notifications to help users find relevant events at the right time. By reducing the needed steps between deciding “I want to play” and actually finding a game, our app turns a traditionally high-effort coordination process into a low-effort mobile interaction.

2. Does this app utilize any of the strengths of the mobile platform?

Our app takes advantage of several strengths of the mobile platform, especially portability, location awareness, and notifications. Because users carry their phones throughout the day, they can quickly check for nearby pickup games whenever they become available. GPS allows the app to show events based on the user’s current location, while the touch-based map interface makes it easy to explore nearby options. Mobile notifications can also alert users about new games, event updates, or upcoming start times, making the platform especially useful for spontaneous recreational sports.

3. What are the main features of the app?

Feature	Details
Map-based match discovery	Users can view nearby pickup sport events on a map, filtered by location, sport, and time.
One-tap join	Players can quickly join an event
Clear-view match management	Organizers can see attendance, event details, and updates without managing responses through group chats.
Player network	Users can add people they meet through games and build a network of players they may want to play with again.

Post-game ratings and feedback	After an event, users can provide lightweight feedback, such as who they enjoyed playing with or who demonstrated good sportsmanship, helping build trust for public events.
Push notifications	Users can receive reminders about upcoming games, event changes, invitations from friends, and potentially relevant nearby events.

We excluded some additional features, such as private events + invites, facility reservation, sports coaching, and expansion to other organized hobbies. While these could be useful future extensions, they aren't necessary to test the app's main purpose: making it easier to discover, organize, and join recreational sports.

4. Who are the target users of the application?

Our target users are adults who want to participate in recreational sports, particularly three groups: organizers, who currently spend significant time coordinating games; match-seekers, who want to play but do not want the burden of organizing; and newcomers, who want to play but do not yet have a local sports network. We primarily target young to middle-aged adults who are bored and want to play sports during their downtime for fitness and socializing. According to the Physical Activity Council, 37.1% of Millennials and 59.6% of Gen Z participated in team sports in 2025. If our app could get to approximately one in four active team-sport participants in a region, that would put us at roughly 9–15% of the population within these younger age groups. These users would be interested in our app because it reduces the effort required to organize a game, discover available games, and find people nearby who want to play the same sport at the same time.

5. What is the pain point that your app addresses?

The pain point our app addresses is the difficulty of finding enough people to play a recreational sport at the time and place you want, especially when you do not already know many people in the area. Around CMU alone, there are more than 20 public group chats and several student clubs that organize pickup sports, yet even these inefficient channels are hidden from newcomers. Even after finding a group, organizing a game is inefficient. Players often rely on group chats, availability polls, and repeated messages days in advance to figure out who's coming, when they are available, and whether enough people will show up. As a result, simply organizing or joining a casual game can require unnecessary time, communication, and coordination.

6. What is the value provided by the app?

Our app reduces the time and effort required to organize and participate in recreational sports. Currently, organizers often have to search through contacts and multiple group chats, invite players individually, track responses, and repeatedly communicate when and where a game will happen. With our app, an organizer can simply post a game and allow interested players nearby to join directly.

For players, our app removes the difficulty of finding an existing group or knowing where games are happening. Someone who simply wants to play basketball, soccer, or another recreational sport after work can open the app, see nearby events, and join one in just a few taps. Beyond convenience, our app makes recreational sports more accessible and social by connecting people who want to play but may not already belong to the same friend group or sports community.

7. What is your app's lifespan? Opportunity for return users?

We expect our app's lifespan to be over a long period (over a year) because recreational sports are not something that users do a couple of times a year, but rather repeatedly. A user might use the app several times a week, as they are actively looking for games to play during the week. However, the duration of each stay is not very long because it is a quick scan through the map of what games are planned that day or searching for what event your friends are participating in. As users continue to use the app to build a network of friends, information on preferred sports, past events, and gameplay ratings, the app can provide increasingly personalized recommendations to further advance the ease of finding a match, and the established network and community on the app can also make future games easier to organize.

8. What has been learned from user research performed to date to support these positions?

Here are some of the main takeaways from our user research performed on 5 different potential users as well as active participants of pickup sports
(Full Interview details are attached as an Appendix at the end of the document)

1. Field availability is a major source of uncertainty, and users **hate** uncertainty
2. Existing **group chats are inefficient** for organizing games
3. Finding **enough committed players** is difficult
4. **Skill-level mismatch** is a recurring problem
5. Moving to a **new area causes great inconvenience** in finding a group to join
6. **Match satisfaction** matters more than finding the match

7. People are **not willing to pay just to be able to find games** in our ecosystem
8. People are **willing to pay to reduce the uncertainty of having an unreliable or low-quality pickup experience.**

9. What (if any) existing APIs are you planning on using?

We plan to use the Google Maps Platform APIs to support the location-based features of our app. Google Maps SDK will allow us to display nearby sporting events directly on an interactive map, while the Places API can help users search for and select locations such as parks, gyms, and athletic fields. The two APIs fit our design because location is one of the main factors users use to discover and join nearby games.

10. What is the biggest foreseeable challenge for implementation?

I think the biggest implementation challenge will be building the map-based event system. We plan to use the Google Maps API, but connecting map pins to many real-time event information may be difficult. Each pin will need to update correctly as events are created, joined, or changed while only showing information that a particular user is allowed to see. To address this, we would use Google Maps for the map and marker functionality while storing event, user, and friendship data in our own backend. We would build the feature incrementally, starting with basic event creation and location-based discovery. Then, we will gradually add live attendance updates, private-event permissions, and friend-based visibility.

Competitor Analysis

Competitor #1: GoodRec

Summary: GoodRec is an app that helps users find pickup sports in their area. Users create an account, choose their location, and search for games nearby. Each user has a customizable profile associated with their account. The app also has a chat feature, allowing users to facilitate games and build connections.

Strengths: GoodRec seems to be the most popular option for finding pickup sports on the Apple App Store. It has 14,000+ reviews and a 4.9/5 star rating, indicating an overwhelmingly positive user experience. The app also appears to have a relatively strong user base, as most major cities have multiple games listed for upcoming days.

For users looking to find games, GoodRec does a good job of introducing them to the host of each game. It includes a link to the host's profile, the number of games they have hosted, and ratings from their previous games.

Weaknesses: The app itself is very underdeveloped, containing only the most necessary features. Additionally, only relatively major cities in the US and Canada are listed as locations, making it difficult for users outside of these cities to find games nearby. In most cities, only soccer and volleyball are listed as supported sports. On top of this, there do not appear to be any free games available for users, as each game has an associated $15.99 charge. Users are also not immediately allowed to post or host games themselves. To host a game, a user must first apply to become a GoodRec partner and be approved.

Key Differentiators: Our app will contain a map feature, allowing users to select locations and find events anywhere. Our app will also support all sports, rather than just soccer and volleyball. Further, any user will be able to post or host a game/event, rather than only approved partners. Our app will also support free games for users.

Conclusion: Overall, GoodRec is a relatively limited competitor for our app. The app experience is fairly basic, and each game comes with a sizable paywall. However, it does seem to have a strong user base, with multiple games available in many cities for each upcoming day. Despite this, the app is relatively underdeveloped, providing our app with an opportunity in the pickup sports space.

Competitor #2: MeetUp

Summary: MeetUp is an app that helps users meet new people and facilitate events. Users create an account, select their interests, choose their location, and find events that interest them. The app allows users to find events and join groups in their area. MeetUp also has a chat feature, allowing users to facilitate games and build connections.

Strengths: The app is extremely popular on the Apple App Store, with 273,000+ ratings and a 4.7/5 star rating. The app is also very well developed, offering many options and features. It offers an explore page, allowing users to find specific events and groups. Further, the group feature does a great job of helping users meet new people and build communities. At any point, users can select their interests and location, and the app will suggest new groups tailored to their choices. The app also seems to have a very strong user base, with many different group and event options listed for each upcoming day. Additionally, the app does a good job of introducing the host or club hosting the event and recommending similar future events.

Weaknesses: Although there are many different options, the app is clearly not tailored toward finding sports. The sports category overall is almost empty of events. Further, sports events are normally associated with a $5.00+ charge for attendance. Users are also not able to create communities or host events without first paying a $300/year charge (or $12.99/week).

Key Differentiators: Our app will be mainly focused on helping users find pickup sports events and groups in specific areas. MeetUp does allow for this, but there are very few sporting events or groups posted on the app. Further, our app will allow any user to post or host events and create groups for free.

Conclusion: Overall, MeetUp is a relatively limited competitor for our app in the pickup sports space. Despite its huge popularity and user base, the app does not seem to have many posted sporting events or groups. This provides our app with an opportunity to focus specifically on the pickup sports market. However, MeetUp is very well developed and supports many features that we will aim to incorporate.

Desirability-Viability-Feasibility

Desirability: Our app addresses a clear inefficiency in recreational sports: finding enough people to play with at the right place and time often requires searching through multiple group chats, repeatedly checking availability, and manually coordinating participants. By allowing users to discover nearby games and join them with only a few taps, the app reduces this friction for organizers, match-seekers, and newcomers. Because recreational sports are already a recurring activity for a large population, we believe simplifying the process of making a game happen provides meaningful value to users.

Viability: Viability is the largest uncertainty because our app depends on having enough local users and events for the platform to remain useful. Users may also be reluctant to leave group chats they already use for organizing sports. Rather than requiring them to immediately change their existing habits, our app can complement these group chats through easily shareable event links. Organizers can continue communicating through their existing groups while using our app as the central place for attendance, location, time, and event information. We would initially focus on a dense community such as the CMU and Pitt area, where existing pickup-sports communities can provide enough activity for the platform to demonstrate its value and encourage repeat use.

Feasibility: The core version of our app is technically achievable within the scope of the semester because it primarily combines established mobile technologies rather than requiring entirely new technology. Google Maps can provide the map and location functionality, while our own backend can manage users, events, attendance, friendships, and privacy. The most challenging component will be keeping location-based event information synchronized as users create, join, and modify games. We can reduce this complexity by developing the app incrementally, beginning with public event creation, map-based discovery, and joining events before adding more advanced features such as private events, recommendations, ratings, and coaching.

Overall, our app satisfies the three criteria well enough to justify development. There is a recognizable user problem and recurring need, a realistic path toward adoption that works alongside existing behaviors, and a technically achievable MVP that can be expanded as the concept is validated.

Appendix I: User Research (6 Interviews)

Participants each have the following background information:

Participant	Related Info
Participant #1	Junior CMU Student. Plays 1-2 pickups a week, mostly around CMU. Often is the organizer for pickups. Likes to play pickup for personal fitness and spending time with friends.
Participant #2	Senior Pitt Student. Plays 2-3 pickups per week. Plays at various locations around CMU and Pitt. Is a member of three different group chats that serve the purpose of scheduling pickups. Played serious soccer until high school. Wants to maintain his skill level but is struggling without regularly organized events.
Participant #3	Senior CMU student-athlete. Doesn't play pickup during the off-season, but seeks to play during the off-season. Wants to participate in matches that are high-level
Participant #4	Senior CMU student-athlete. Wants to find ways to continue playing even when the career is over. Like participant #3, wants to play competitively.
Participant #5	Ph.D. student at Pitt. Former student-athlete. Plays about 1-2 pickups a week. Plays for fun now, but wants to play at a satisfactory level

Participant #6	Freshman CMU student. Playing basketball more in college, mainly with friends and solo when none are available. Doesn't play super competitively, just casual with friends and whoever is at court.

Participant #1

Problems experienced in playing pickup soccer? What inconvenience is there?

- There is so much uncertainty in the availability of the field, which always makes playing pickup soccer a bet on that day's session
- There are often too few times and too little information on fields regarding open hours, reservation availability, lights, and field equipments

Problem w/ group chats to organize pickups?

- Doesn't feel comfortable communicating with people through the group chat when the interviewee doesn't feel too close with them.
- It is only an effective means of communicating when it is between friends.

How would you play soccer when you move to a new area?

- Won't play due to the inconvenience that comes with finding new people to play with
- Will consider playing only once

Are you willing to pay $5 per month to use the service? If yes, are you willing to pay now to reserve a spot when the app is released to be subscribed at $4 per month?

- No. He will just go to the field to join random people if payment is required.
- Willing to pay if the planned matches on the app reserve a field and guarantee the type of well-mannered match that is expected.
- Also willing to pay for any organized recreational tournaments in the area.

Show them the picture of our prototype. What do you like, what do you dislike?
Why would you prefer it over other means? Why would you not?

- The participant likes the rating system.
- The participant thinks that this will allow them to decide the expected level of play for a match to see if it would fit his skill level.

Participant #2

Inconvenience in scheduling pickup sports

- Not everybody has the same free time
- Not everybody is that into soccer

- Field availability is unknown

Inconvenience with scheduling through group chat

- Too Many people ghosting
- Hard to communicate in the midst of various contents

How would you play soccer when you move to a new area?

- Continuously ask friends until somebody who plays pickup is found.
- Go to local soccer fields and play; get their contact

Show them the picture of our prototype. What do you like, what do you dislike?
Why would you prefer it over other means? Why would you not?

Positives

- Convenient to play soccer
- Easy to add + sign-ups
- Good anticipation of the approximate skill level of the match

Negative

- Once find a group, I don't want to continue playing with strangers

Are you willing to pay $5 per month to use the service? If yes, are you willing to pay now to reserve a spot when the app is released to be subscribed at $4 per month?

- Would only pay if enough people are on the app

<u>Participant #3</u>

How do you play or plan on playing pick-up sports?

- Would use social media. Would just be looking until something popped up.
- Would like a way to find groups and events.
- Would like a way to filter on skill level.

Problems experienced in playing pickup soccer? What inconvenience is there?

- People not showing up/ghosting
- Selfish players
- Mismatch of skill level

Inconvenience with scheduling through group chat

- Group chats get distracted. Like the message and then move on.
- People can forget and get sidetracked from the actual event.

How would you play soccer when you move to a new area?

- Connections in the area or through social media (instagram)

Are you willing to pay $5 per month to use the service? If yes, are you willing to pay now to reserve a spot when the app is released to be subscribed at $4 per month?

- Yes, would be willing to pay $5 for an app that suits them. Yes, would be willing to reserve a spot.

Show them the picture of our prototype. What do you like? What do you dislike?
Why would you prefer it over other means? Why would you not?
Potential Ideas for prototype:

- Hosts should be paying more than the user
- Would use the app for more than just soccer (other hobbies as well). Tennis, Pickleball, Basketball

Participant #4

How do you play or plan on playing pickup sports?

- Would probably use Instagram, asking people they know.
- Look on Facebook for groups

Problems experienced in playing pickup soccer? What inconvenience is there?

- Mismatch in skill levels.
- Lack of keepers and equipment.
- Unknown numbers of participants.

Inconvenience with scheduling through group chat

- People get sidetracked easily.
- Messages get lost after a while.

How would you play soccer when you move to a new area?

- Connections in the area or through social media (Instagram)

Are you willing to pay $5 per month to use the service? If yes, are you willing to pay now to reserve a spot when the app is released to be subscribed at $4 per month?

- No, just look on Instagram or Facebook for groups. Search for leagues online as well.
- However, would be willing to pay to participate in leagues.

Show them the picture of our prototype. What do you like, what do you dislike?
Why would you prefer it over other means? Why would you not?

- Potential Ideas for prototype:
- Have associated groups able to host leagues and events
- Have RSVP
- Have a way to pin messages to Group chat or to profile

Participant #5

How do you play or plan on playing pickup sports?

- At first, going to the field random, ask if he can join
- Eventually, added to the group chat

Problems experienced in playing pickup soccer? What inconvenience is there?

- Occasionally play with players with bad manner, but they stick with the group
- Start times are often not as planned: People come late consistently

Problem w/ group chats?

- Polls are inaccurate
- Participant numbers are inaccurate

How would you play soccer when you move to a new area?

- Go out to field in the evening at around 8 pm when most people seem to come out
- Approach the group that is playing if joining is possible

Are you willing to pay $5 per month to use the service? If yes, are you willing to pay now to reserve a spot when the app is released to be subscribed at $4 per month?

- Not willing to pay unless I am new to the area. Would only pay to find a group and then cancel.

Show them the picture of our prototype. What do you like, what do you dislike?
Why would you prefer it over other means? Why would you not?

Positive

- Additional details posted about events
- Map view helps sketch what play is on around me
- Rating System should be beneficial to sort out bad players
- Connecting with people through the app

Negative

- Rating is often not incentivized
- Some more bio on Users in the same games would help (maybe different tags)

Participant #6

How do you play or plan on playing pick up sports?

- Go to Highmark and text friends

Problems experienced in playing pickup soccer? What inconvenience is there?

- Oftentimes reserved by other club/team or event

Problem w/ group chats?

- Friends don't wanna play
- Friends keep forgetting time and place

How would you play soccer when you move to a new area?

- Hopefully make some friends
- Pull up to whatever court nearby

Are you willing to pay $5 per month to use the service? If yes, are you willing to pay now to reserve a spot when the app is released to be subscribed at $4 per month?

- No, would prefer to use it only for free

Show them the picture of our prototype. What do you like, what do you dislike?
Why would you prefer it over other means? Why would you not?
Positive

- Love being able to see where the different courts are; helpful in a new area
- Loves the friends feature

Negative

- Don't like roster, feels limited
- Likes calendar and share to group feature
- Doesn't like not being able to see all the available courts

Appendix II: AI-Created Prototype Images

- Used for brainstorming
- Used in our interviews to give some visualization



